

[RESEARCH OUR RECORDS](#)[VETERANS' SERVICE RECORDS](#)[EDUCATOR RESOURCES](#)[VISIT US](#)[AMERICA'S FOUNDING DOCUMENTS](#)

Research Our Records

[Home](#) > [Research Our Records](#) > [Getting Started Overview](#)

Getting Started Overview

Here's how to start researching records at the National Archives:

Get Started

- Step 1 [Determine your Topic of Interest](#)
- Step 2 [Gather Information about your Topic](#)
- Step 3 [Find Records and Information about Records](#)
- Step 4 [Decide if you Should Visit and Plan Your Visit](#)

About the Records at the National Archives

Of all documents and materials created in the course of business conducted by the United States Federal government, only 1%-3% are so important for legal or historical reasons that they are kept forever. Those valuable records are preserved in the National Archives and are available to you, whether you want to see if they contain clues about your family's history, need to prove a veteran's military service, or are researching a historical topic that interests you.

Research News and Notices

FAQs

[Using the National Archives Web Site](#)[Basics about Research at the National Archives](#)[Visiting the National Archives](#)[Two Steps Every Researcher Should Take](#)[All FAQs](#)

Learning Resources

["Know Your Records" series on YouTube](#)

When You Arrive

[Get your Research Card Orientation for Researchers](#)

Rules

[Research Rooms Guidance](#)[Research Room Rules](#)[Research by Minors](#)

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security measures at the National Archives in Washington, DC, as well as how to use the research room and records.

Online Services Available for Free in our Research Rooms

[The Archives Library's Online Public Access Catalog](#)

[America: History & Life](#)

[Ancestry](#)

[ArchivesUSA™](#)

[Family Search](#)

[Fold3](#) (formerly Footnote.com)

[GaleNet's Biography and Genealogy Master Index](#)

[ProQuest/UMI Heritage Quest Online](#)

[ProQuest Direct](#)

[More Free Databases at National Archives Facilities](#)

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Research Our Records

Online Research

- [By Topic](#)
- [By Format](#)
- [By Government Organization](#)
- [National Archives Catalog](#)
- [Presidential Records](#)
- [Access to Archival Databases](#)
- [Archives Library Information Center](#)
- [Online Exhibits](#)

Resources For...

- [Genealogists](#)
- [Military Historians](#)
- [Preservation and Archives Professionals](#)
- [Records Managers](#)
- [Veterans](#)

Research Guides

- [Getting Started](#)
- [National Archives Frequently Asked Questions](#)
- [Guide to Federal Records](#)
- [Declassified Records](#)
- [Where to Look for Records](#)
- [Why Aren't All Records Online?](#)
- [How to File a FOIA Request for Archival Records](#)

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- [News and Notices](#)
- [New Accessions](#)



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